

RAJWANT RAWAT

This preoccupation with 'shuruaat can also be found in Broota's 'The Source I-III', a trilogy of woodcut-on-paper works from 1987.

*Painting Infinity* is divided into five sections, each corresponding to a different phase in Broota's storied career. The 'Origin' series is part of the 'Seed of Life' section, while her work with wool, net, paper et al is covered in the section titled 'Woven Echoes'. According to Broota, these works exist because she was looking for "a softer line" after decades of working with brushes and paints. This impulse manifests in her acrylic-and-oil works as well. 'Celestial Music', for example, is a 2002 work (acrylic and oil on canvas, 70 x 70 inches) that resembles the double-helical DNA molecule. The 'softer line' that Broota refers to makes every 'strand' look unique in its own right and yet there is a uniformity of purpose. 'Wholeness Within' (2008, acrylic and oil on canvas, 72 x 72 inches) creates a similar duality, the two halves of the circular form looking like the rising and the setting sun, respectively—one of several paintings with nature-themed motifs.

"From a young age, I was good at observing nature," says Broota. "The birds emerging out of the trees with the rising sun, animals gathered near a stream to drink water, that sort of thing. My father, an architect, had a lot of drawing materials around the house and eventually I started exploring. Drawing trees or birds or gardens, the things that I would see all around me. If you want to paint, you have to be a keen observer, that's the first step."

The concluding section of the exhibition, 'Portraits in Time', includes Broota's early-career works, including some photo-realistic portraiture. By the 1970s, Broota's expert draftsmanship and a good word-of-mouth reputation would regularly land her lucrative gigs drawing prominent people. Portraits of German artists and intellectuals like Ina Seidel and Mary Wigman are part of this section, as is a striking self-portrait from 1962 (oil-on-canvas, 23.7 x 20.2 inches). Ultimately, the routine of capturing facial features for money started boring Broota, and she moved towards more abstract expressions.

"For an artist, it's very important to keep moving towards the next thing," says Broota. "Doing portraits got me money and recognition but, after a while, it was just me showing off the same technique, the same light-and-shadow tricks. It was skilled work, but it was repetitive, so I had to move on. Even today, when I am in the studio, I am constantly thinking about the next idea. That's what still drives me as an artist."

Overall, *Painting Infinity* is a brilliant, wide-ranging entry point for those unfamiliar with Broota's diverse body of work. ■

***—Aditya Mani Jha***

*The exhibition is on display at DAG, New Delhi, till Oct. 18*





He was also instrumental in the post-Independence Delhi Shilpi Chakra movement—a parallel movement to the Progressive Artists' Group in Bombay—aimed at fostering self-reliance among artists. Kulkarni taught Master's students at Delhi College of Art as a visiting faculty member, and was also appointed dean of the Faculty of Fine Arts and head of the painting department at Banaras Hindu University.

The works on display reflect Kulkarni's distinctive visual vocabulary—marked by geometric encapsulation of space, linear dynamism and flat planes of colour. The exhibition showcases his ability to seamlessly navigate a spectrum of themes—from intricate drawings to abstract and figurative compositions. His compositions synthesise influences from both eEastern and Western traditions, yet remain unmistakably his own. Unlike many of his contemporaries, Kulkarni resisted stylistic categorisation, creating art that is timeless, contemporary and multidimensional.

**KULKARNI'S WORK COMBINES INFLUENCES FROM THE EAST AND WEST, RESISTING CATEGORISATION AND BECOMING TIMELESS**

This show is especially meaningful for Gallerie Ganesha, as Kulkarni was both a mentor and the first exhibiting artist of the gallery. Founder and curator Shobha Bhatia began her journey in the art world with a solo show by Kulkarni nearly 36 years ago, making this a poignant return to the gallery's roots. "His work, though unmistakably modern, carried deep influences from folk and tribal art. His ability to manipulate form, space and colour in an unparalleled manner resulted in the creation of masterpieces," says Bhatia. ■

***—Neha Kirpal***

Esoteric Expressions *runs till Oct. 7 at Gallerie Ganesha, New Delhi*